visions and forging sculptures that presented material form with suggestive voids, membrane surfaces, visible negative spaces, and inferred connections.

For example, Tajiri named his sculpture *Wounded Knee, 1890* (1953) after the nineteenth-century U.S. Army's clash with the Lakota at the Pine Ridge Indian Reservation, which resulted in the massacre of more than 200 indigenous civilians. His chosen nomenclature conjures land theft, border conflicts, and the importance of the date in a history of national violence. Tajiri's surrealist ironwork has the surface of a cell membrane, climbs to over three feet to nearly resemble a small tower or satellite, and stands on three talon-like legs. Sharp objects including arrows, thorns, and scissors are abstracted as menacing spikes protruding off its top-half surface, with a hook engulfed in its visible midsection. When he later carved a representation of this sculpture on scraperboard for a retrospective book, he placed a black-and-white American flag under its base to conjure a military coffin.[34]

In 1958, in another set of sculptures called *Tower of Babel* or *Columns for Meditation,* Tajiri reflected on the "gap in communication" between the superpowers during the Cold War. He had pioneered a method of carving an inverse design into porous bricks. He sculpted not to build out, but through the reduction of form, effectively making a mold inside the bricks. He then poured a molten material into this cast to form the artwork, creating a complex representation of an upwardly built structure that is more allegorical than historically specific. Each tower comprises stacked levels that look like rooms, each one unique, leading to a top that resembles a rooster feather or a wilted leaf. Each level appears sturdy when all are viewed as strata on top of one another, and yet as a whole the towers are ashen, brittle, and suggestive of an impending crumble.[35]

Tajiri's *Made in* USA series, built in conjunction with a yearlong teaching residency at the Minneapolis Institute of Art (his longest return to the United States since the 1940s) consisted of over a dozen sculptures and related "machines." He reflected on the U.S. role in Vietnam and the ways technology is oriented to conduct war without face-to-face human interaction. Within this series, the sculptures carried either names like *Fortress* or *Tank* or just identifying numbers. Each had legs, as if to anthropomorphize them, but they also looked like hybrid figures, composed of abstracted, recognizable features of insects, leaves, high-tech weapons, and robots.[36] Tajiri wove together expressions of technology and grotesque nature. He pondered human intentions in leveraging creative energies toward